

The Instructions Sheet

The difference between an instruction that nearly works and one that works.

THE FOUR THINGS, IN ORDER OF DIFFERENCE MADE

THING	WEAK	STRONG
Who is doing it	Review this	You are a careful reviewer who cannot change anything
What comes out	Summarise the week	Three bullets per client: what moved, what is blocked, what is next
What not to do	Be accurate	Do not invent progress. If a client has nothing, say so
When to stop	Fix the problems	Report problems. Do not change any files

HOW TO FIND YOUR OWN NOT-TO-DO LINE

- **What did you have to say twice?** Look back at your last few sessions and find it.
- Write it in the words you would use if you were annoyed, and put it in as written.
- That single line does more than any amount of describing the good version. It is also the one that gets skipped.

LET IT INTERVIEW YOU INSTEAD OF DRAFTING

Five minutes of answers beats an hour of writing

Here is an instruction I use. It nearly works, and the thing I keep correcting is: [what you keep correcting].

[paste your instruction]

Interview me to fix it. One question at a time, wait for my answer. Cover: who is doing it, exactly what should come out, what it must never do, and when it should stop.

Then rewrite it. Keep it short.

SIX SHAPES WORTH HAVING

JOB	THE LINE THAT MAKES IT WORK
Review	Report problems. Change nothing.
Summarise	Fixed number of bullets. Say when there is nothing.
Research	Say what you could not find, rather than filling the gap.
Check	List what failed. Do not fix anything.
Convert	Keep every field. Flag anything that will not map.
Report	Same sections every time, even when a section is empty.

TEST THE FAILURE, NOT THE SUCCESS

Anyone can test the happy path, and it already worked. Run it on the case that used to go wrong. That is the only test that tells you whether the rewrite was worth anything.